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TELEGRAMS, "AQUILAE, LONDON"
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ROYAL SOCIETIES CLUB,
ST. JAMES'S STREET,
S.W.1.

29 Halkyard Rd

Bridford. Sunday, 18.XII.21

Dear Mr Russell,

I have just thought of a way of making my
x.y.z business a little less vague. It is only
an analogy, but it illustrates what I'm thinking
of. I took x = the part, y = the part that is
concerned, z as the context i.e. that part of x
which is not y and by means of which y is 'seen'.

The analogy is this: Speech sounds are made of
vowels & consonants: in vowels the sound (i.e. the
audibility of it) is produced by air + vibration +
[modification of] the shape of the opening: in other words
it is vibration modified by pressure. In consonants
we have air obstructed & every consonant can be
made with or without vibration (voiced or unvoiced).

If we call the 'thing' y a vowel kind of thing,
and z a consonant kind of thing, and when z
is stressed it is 'voiced' & when it is odd it is
'unvoiced', then is enough analogy I think to

show the kind of thing I am looking after.

You may remember that you told me I was wrong in supposing that there was no difference between math^s & language. Another maintains that 'one' is language, & that 'two' isn't. I don't follow him. The best I can do at present is to say that I am now sure you are right & that the nearest I can get to any statement of the difference is this: the mathematical one is conspicuous in the absence of background; the logical one is conspicuous by its absence in a background. I add this only in the hope that it may throw ~~some~~ some light on the vacuum business!

Yours sincerely

W. V. Quine